

Every American Mahjong set has three numbered suits, plus Winds, Dragons, Flowers and Jokers. Keep this beside your rack until you can name a tile without thinking.

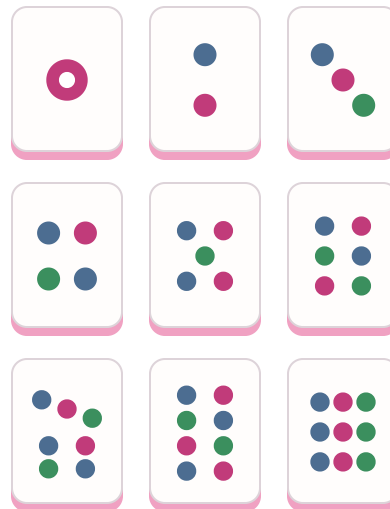
Craks

Characters, 1 to 9. The number on top is what you read aloud.



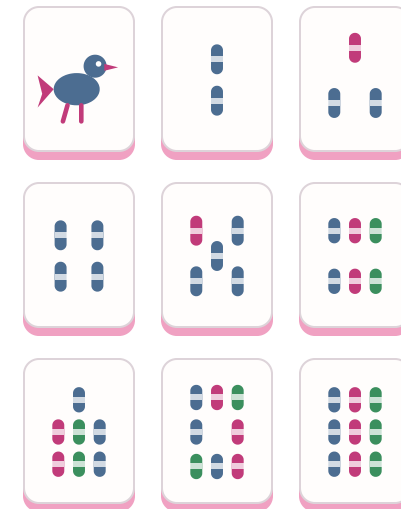
Dots

Circles, 1 to 9. Count the circles.



Bams

Bamboos, 1 to 9. The 1 Bam is usually a bird.



Dragons



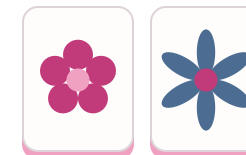
Red • White ("Soap") • Green

Winds



North • East • South • West

Flowers



All Flowers are interchangeable

Jokers



8 in a set



Pair

No Jokers



Pung

Jokers OK



Kong

Jokers OK



Quint

Needs a Joker



Sextet

Needs 2 Jokers

The Joker rule. Jokers can fill any group of three or more, never a single or a pair. Green Dragon goes with Bams, Red Dragon with Craks, Soap with Dots.

1 Starting hand

Look for pairs

Pairs anchor your hand, because Jokers can never stand in for them.

Notice patterns

Lots of evens? Consecutive numbers? The same number in two suits?

Keep options open

Aim at a section of the card, not one line. Keep two or three directions alive.



2 The Charleston

Keep

- Jokers, always
- Your natural pairs
- Tiles that fit more than one direction

Pass

- Isolated singles
- Winds and Dragons you don't need
- Three unrelated tiles: a "salad"

Watch out

- **Never pass a Joker.**
- Don't break a good pair because you feel rushed
- Short of three safe tiles on the last pass? Blind pass some of the incoming tiles

Right → Across → Left, then (if all agree) Left → Across → Right



3 Your turn

Draw

Take the next tile from the wall, or call a discard if it completes a group of three or more.

Reassess

Did this tile improve your plan, or point to a better line on the card?

Exchange

Holding the natural tile for a Joker sitting in someone's exposure? Swap it now.

Discard

Put one tile face up in the middle and say its name clearly.



4 Hand falling apart?

Are the pairs you need still realistic? Are too many of your tiles already discarded or exposed? **Changing direction is part of the game, not failure.** Pivot before you expose tiles, because exposures lock you in.

5 Before you say "Mahjong"

- ☐ Exactly matches one line on the current card?
- ☐ Right number of suits for the colors shown?
- ☐ Singles and pairs are natural tiles, no Jokers?
- ☐ Fourteen tiles, counted twice?